



VA PARTNER POLICY

WARNING

Information contained in this document is
intended for flight simulation purposes only.

1. Control Pages

1.1. Document Identification

Document Identification	
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Version	1.3
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1.2. Revision Records

Revision Number	Date	Description of Change	Author
1.0	20 Aug 2020	Published.	Roger C.
1.1	01 Oct 2022	Full policy overhaul.	Antonio D.
1.2	01 Jan 2023	Requirements update for partner flight requirement. 6.7	Antonio D.
1.3	24 Apr 2024	Design, structure & requirements update.	Antonio D./ Joe B.
1.4		Requirements update for partner flight requirement. 6.7	Joe B.

1.3. Related Documents

Document Name	Document Identification
VATSIM Virtual Airline Associate Policy	VATSIM-VAA-P

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2. Purpose

From its inception in 2001, **VATSIM** has recognized the popularity of virtual airlines (**VA**) and the desire of pilots to operate aircraft on the network utilizing airline call signs, aircraft, and procedures. As a result, the Virtual Airlines and Special Operations Department was created and placed under the management and authority of a Vice-President dedicated to that department. It was determined that it would be beneficial to **VATSIM** to establish a cadre of partner airlines that could be recommended to members seeking to join a virtual airline. In return, being established as a Partner provided an opportunity for said VAs to make their presence known and potentially recruit new members to their rosters. It was decided that there should be certain criteria to qualify a VA for Partner status and to retain that status, that there should be a formal policy to regulate said qualifications, and a means to verify continued eligibility.

This document shall serve as the written document of requirements and daily operational procedures for all Virtual/Simulated civilian airlines and organizations that wish to use the **VATSIM** network for online flight simulation.

3. Applicability

This policy applies to:

- 3.1. All VATSIM Pilots and Air Traffic Control Divisions on the VATSIM network conducting any type of event, activity, or operation described in this document.
- 3.2. Virtual Airline organizations that are taking part in VATSIM's Virtual Airline Partner program.

4. Authority

In accordance with the **VATSIM Code of Regulations**, the VATSIM Vice President of Virtual Airlines and Special Operations (**VPVASO**), shall be the determining authority for all individuals and organizations wishing to utilize the VATSIM network for events and activities described in this document.

- 4.1. Like any other segment of VATSIM, the VPVASO has a specified chain of command. All positions below the VPVASO may be filled as needed by appointment of the VPVASO. The following positions created are:

4.1.1. Director of Virtual Airlines

4.1.2. Senior Audit Manager

4.1.3. Senior Developer

4.1.4. Audit Manager

4.1.5. Developer

In the absence of VPVASO, the appointed Director of Virtual Airlines assumes authority over departmental responsibilities and its administrative tasks, including any other responsibilities outlined in this document.

- 4.2. The **VPVASO** has the authority to remove any individual or organization from the Virtual Airline Partnership program (**VASO**), thereby suspending their privilege to conduct any event, benefit, right or activity described in this document. An email notice of removal will be sent to the member and/or organization and to the VATSIM Vice President of Conflict Resolution (**VPCR**). The **VPCR** may review a removal and provide the targeted party or parties with an appeals process.

5. Onboarding

In order to become a VATSIM Virtual Airline Partner (**VAP**), a petitioning VA should visit [myVATSIM](#) and apply. Applicants should meet all VAP requirements. If the Virtual Airline does not meet the requirements for the **VA Partner Program**, it may be automatically onboarded onto the **VA Associate Program**, in which case the applicant should become familiar with the VATSIM VA Associate Program policy.

After the partner application is received, the onboarding process may take up to **14 days**. Applicants are encouraged to ensure they meet **all requirements** to prevent their application from being rejected and/or sent to the back of the application queue.

Multiple submissions of applications without addressing the previous rejection reason(s), or submitting the application on behalf of an organization which they are not a part of, may result in disciplinary action against the applicant's **VATSIM membership**

6. Requirements

6.1. Management supports VATSIM and encourages pilots to fly online.

As an online flight simulation network, our mission is to provide an aviation experience for pilots and air traffic controllers. Encouraging and sustaining use of the network is the primary means of achieving this goal. Therefore, we seek to partner with virtual airlines that make an effort to encourage their pilots to fly their flights with the airline online using the VATSIM network.

6.2. VA in existence minimum of six months.

Virtual Airlines are created all the time but many fail to either achieve a critical mass of members or maintain the management commitment for a significant period and are quickly abandoned. A VA that has been in existence for six months or more is likely to have overcome the initial problems that doom many startups.

6.3. Functional and secure website.

In most cases, websites are used as gateways for pilots to interact with their VA accounts, which includes private data. We require all VAP websites to meet the following:

6.3.1. Partner websites are required to pass all traffic through the HTTPS protocol, instead of HTTP. This requires the website to have an SSL certificate. This ensures an extra layer of security and helps protect against attacks. It ensures that the data transmitted between the client and server is encrypted and cannot be intercepted by third parties. As a free alternative, we recommend using <https://letsencrypt.org>.

6.4. Display the VATSIM VA Partner logo OR the VATSIM logo that points to <https://vatsim.net>.

We display your banner as a partner airline and require that you display ours. The VATSIM logo must be featured either on the VA website homepage or in a clearly marked Partners section. Either of the following logos may be used:

6.4.1. Official VATSIM logo obtained from <https://vats.im/logo>.

6.4.2. Official VATSIM VA Partner logo obtained from <https://vats.im/vaplogo>.

Please keep in mind that when using the VATSIM brand you must conform to the guidelines found at <https://vats.im/brand>.

6.5. Active email address.

VATSIM's Audit Managers must be able to contact an official from each VA Partner. Upon submitting an application, and it being approved, the VA is linked to the applicant's VATSIM account, and their primary address is used as the contact address for any VA related inquiries. The VA may contact the department officials to request a different address be set as the contact address.

6.6. VA callsign ICAOs.

While there are no limitations as to how many callsigns the VA may utilize on the network, we require them to provide us with the list of Callsign ICAOs their pilots use when flying on the network. This should either be submitted upon applying for partner status, or upon request by an audit manager.

Please keep in mind that the VA department does not regulate callsigns lists on VATSIM globally. The purpose of requesting ICAOs is used for activity verification and to be provided to 3rd parties that make use of <https://va.vatsim.net> public API.

6.7. 50+ flights on the VATSIM network by a minimum of 15 different pilots using ICAO callsign used by that VA in the past 90 days.

The presence of at least 50 flights online on the VA roster indicates that it has achieved some level of acceptance in the pilot community by a number of dedicated members. Having pilots utilize the VATSIM network while conducting flights is why the network exists. Partner VAs are subject to periodic audits every 90 days by VATSIM's Audit Managers to ensure that they are maintaining the requirements for said status. To facilitate these audits, flight records or PIREPs must be made available to the audit managers on request or via a roster that is publicly accessible on the VA website. In exceptions, we will accept a list of pilot CIDs. Flights records/PIREPs should consist of the following information:

6.7.1. Callsign

6.7.2. Origin Airport ICAO

6.7.3. Destination Airport ICAO

6.7.4. Flight Date

6.7.5. Departure Time (Zulu) ^{optional}

6.7.6. Arrival Time (Zulu) ^{optional}

6.7.7. Aircraft Type ^{optional}

6.7.8. Remarks ^{optional}

6.8. Virtual Airlines may not have the exact same names.

Each partner airline will have a distinct name for its listing and no other VAP may utilize the exact same name.

6.9. Software installed on the client's user system.

Any software that VA members need to install to fulfill work for the VA must follow any data restrictions VATSIM imposes to secure the online system. Therefore, while online, any data collection software or programs utilized by a VA must not interfere with, or possibly be harmful to, the VATSIM network. In addition, the VA will not permit any pirated and/or copyright-protected documents, charts, or other files or programs to be posted on or linked from its site without having received prior authorization from the legal owner of said material permitting such use.

6.10. GDPR Compliance as a VA Partner.

Each VA will be required to have their website GDPR compliant by making sure that website has the following information posted on the front page in a very conspicuous location. Each individual VA will have their choice of either placing a pop-up box / modal or a general text box which must include the following:

6.10.1. Consent from each member to have their data collected and used pursuant to the GDPR Privacy Policy.

6.10.2. A link to the GDPR Privacy Policy for members to review.

6.10.3. Actual GDPR Privacy Policy located on the main website for easy access.

When applying for partnership, VAs must include all the requested information from above for the application to be processed promptly.

Upon applying, the applicant states that they are authorized to submit the application as a representative of the Virtual Airline in question.

VAs may be eligible to have the activity requirement waived, if their Virtual Airline has >80% of their total flights on VATSIM.

An organization may be removed from the database at any time for any valid reason as deemed by VATSIM officials to include, but not limited to: Dead links, bad email addresses, continuous misbehavior by pilots on the network, failure to respond to official inquiries in a timely manner (not to exceed one week), or failure to adhere to the above stated partnership requirements.

7. Data Protection

VATSIM's Virtual Airlines department falls under VATSIM's [Privacy Policy](#) and [Data Protection and Handling Policy](#).

7.1. Permissions.

Upon applying, the applicant, on behalf of the Virtual Airline they are representing, gives VATSIM permission to responsibly store the following data:

7.1.1. The applicant's primary VATSIM email address.

7.1.2. The applicant's VATSIM CID.

7.1.3. Virtual Airline Name.

7.1.4. Founding date of the Virtual Airline.

7.1.5. Website URL of the Virtual Airline.

7.1.6. Logo of the Virtual Airline.

7.1.7. Country the Virtual Airline is based in.

7.1.8. Flight data submitted.

7.1.9. Description and any of the selectable tags that match the Virtual Airlines.

Upon the VA being audited, in order to satisfy any requirement the Audit Manager is unable to verify without additional input from the VA, the Audit Manager may send a request, using their officially issued vatsim.net email, to the official contact address of the VA for the required information to complete the audit.

Any data submitted to the Audit Managers, is only to be viewed by the Audit Manager doing the audit, Director of Virtual Airlines and/or Vice President of Virtual Airlines and Special Operations. Upon the Audit being complete, all and any data received from the VA's contact e-mail address will be permanently deleted.

7.2. Accessibility.

Upon an explicit request from a VA, we are obliged to submit to them any and all data we hold about their VA.

7.3. Termination.

The VA reserves the right to request immediate removal from our systems, and all data concerning them, at any given point in time. This process may take up to 96 hours after being received.

8. Benefits and Rights

8.1. Benefits.

Virtual Airline Partners, from the beginning of their status as a Partner until their termination or end, will be entitled to receive the following:

8.1.1. VAPs participating in the program will have their site name and a link to their website published on my.vatsim.net which is visited by many pilots seeking to join a Virtual Airline.

8.1.2. VAPs become eligible to participate in the VATSIM Pilot Training Department as an Authorized Training Organization (ATO).

8.1.3. VAPs are eligible to co-sponsor events with VATSIM ARTCCs/FIRs.

8.1.4. Access to VATSIM VA Discord via which other VA Staff Members can be contacted and coordinated. This includes, but does not guarantee, easier communication and planning with ARTCC/FIR event coordinators.

8.1.5. Exclusive rights allowing the VAPs to create in-house Aircraft Liveries that contain the VATSIM logo under the condition that it follows the guidelines found on <https://vats.im/brand>.

8.1.6. Access to any technical tools developed by the VA Department for VAs that allow for easier data exports necessary for audits (When such are available).

8.1.7. Right to submit VA hosted events on our discord server, to have them publicized via VATSIM media, which includes advertising them on our events twitter, <https://vatsim.net/events>, and 700+ discord servers, including the official community server.

8.1.8. Upon being onboarded, the Virtual Airline is generated a VA-UUID, which is linked to the VA identity at <https://va.vatsim.net> and its respective services, including but not limited to the va.vatsim.net's public API.

8.1.9. Right to submit up to 15 aircraft liveries to be included in the FS Live Traffic Liveries project. More information about FSLTL can be found here: <https://www.fslivetrafficliveries.com>

Abuse of certain benefits and/or not following guidelines where applicable may result in the Virtual Airline becoming disqualified from receiving the benefit(s) at any point in time as the VPVASO deems fit (reference **2. Authority**).

8.2. Rights.

Virtual Airlines partnered with VATSIM, from the beginning of their status as a Partner until their termination or end, receive the following rights:

8.2.1. All benefits provided to VAPs. Reference to **8.1. Benefits.**

8.2.2. Data accessibility concerning the VA. Reference to **7.2. Accessibility.**

8.2.3. Representing themselves as an official partner of VATSIM.

8.2.4. Viewing audit data and results from past periods for their VA.

8.2.5. Immediate termination and deletion, which includes, but is not limited to, requesting a removal from the program, and/or all data stored about the VA. Reference to **7.3. Termination.**

9. Staff and Contact

Our staff list changes from time to time as our volunteers come and go, therefore, we use our forum group to keep our staff list up to date. Any contact from a vatsim.net address is deemed an official contact. Our staff will never contact you from any other addresses.

You can find our staff contacts on the following sources:

- Discord (<https://community.vatsim.net>)
- Forums (<https://forum.vatsim.net/g/virtualairline>)
- Public API (<https://va.vatsim.net/api/auditors>)

For any additional questions, inquiries or complaints, please forward any of such to the VPVASO at vpvas@vatsim.net